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I feel morally elevated by my organization's CSR, so I contribute to it

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ABSTRACT

While research addressing the micro-foundations of corporate social responsibility (CSR) has often built on the deontic theory of justice to explain why employees care about their organization's CSR, the mechanisms underlying this deontic path have seldom been examined. Therefore, we study moral elevation, an other-directed moral emotion that, according to deontic theory of justice, could help us understand why employees may react positively to their organization's CSR even when it does not offer employees significant self-centered benefits. We advance that moral elevation substantiates the deontic mechanism put forward to explain why CSR translates into employees' behavior supporting this CSR. We carry out an experiment and a survey that provide support for this hypothesis. By identifying moral elevation as a mechanism underlying the deontic path, our research provides empirical support for the deontic argument in micro-CSR research that employees care about CSR because CSR is the moral thing to do.

1. Introduction

Complementing the macro-level research linking corporate social responsibility (CSR) with organizational outcomes (Aguinis & Glavas, 2012; Morgeson et al., 2013), the fast growing micro-CSR research stream investigates the psychological foundations at the heart of these relationships (Gond et al., 2017; Gond & Moser, 2019), with a focus on why and how employees react to their organization's CSR (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Ng et al., 2019). Micro-CSR research has repeatedly drawn on the deontic theory of justice to explain why employees care about their organization's CSR, in particular about CSR that is not targeted at the employees themselves (e.g., De Roeck & Farooq, 2018; Dunford et al., 2015; Rupp et al., 2006; Rupp et al., 2013). According to the deontic theory of justice, employees make morality-based judgments (i.e. judgments about what is just) that are independent of how their organization's actions affect them personally, which differs from traditional models of justice where morality is not seen as an end, valued by employees for its own sake, but as a means toward more self-centered benefits (Folger, 2001; Konovsky, 2000). Despite the reliance of the micro-CSR literature on the deontic theory of justice to argue for a link between CSR and employees' responses, the mechanisms underlying this deontic justice "path" have surprisingly not been explored much. Indeed, most of the mechanisms empirically studied in the literature overlook the moral reactions to perceptions of CSR (Gond et al., 2017).

To further explore the deontic justice path, we study moral elevation as a mechanism likely to explain employees' responses to CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder. Moral elevation is an other-directed moral emotion elicited by moral excellence (Aquino et al., 2011) when observing a good deed toward another party (Vianello et al., 2010). Contrary to the social exchange and social identity mechanisms (such as organizational identification and pride) already studied by micro-CSR researchers (De Roeck et al., 2016; Farooq et al., 2017), moral elevation is more directly and uniquely linked to a deontic concern for justice.

Furthermore, we study employees' responses to CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder, which, according to stakeholder theory, is a stakeholder "not engaged in transaction with the corporation and not essential to its survival" (Clarkson, 1995, p. 107), in contrast to primary stakeholders. As "context-specific organizational actions and policies that take into account stakeholders' expectations and the triple bottom line of economic, social and environmental performance" (Aguinis, 2011, p. 855), CSR is multidimensional in nature (El Akremi et al., 2018). CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder – the environment in this research – makes a better case to understand the deontic justice path than CSR targeted at the employees or at other primary stakeholders because, by comparison, employees will see fewer self-centered instrumental and relational benefits from CSR targeted at a secondary

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stakeholder.

Among the various employees' responses CSR could trigger, we examine employees' organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) that supports the CSR targeted at the secondary stakeholder. As we argue below, we expect moral elevation to lead employees to emulate their organization's perceived moral excellence by addressing the needs of the same secondary stakeholder. It is also an interesting type of employees' responses because little attention has been paid so far to how CSR can, through its impact on employees' behavior, affect society at large or the natural environment (Rupp & Mallory, 2015). Given that companies were called to invest in CSR to do better for society and the environment (Carroll, 1991; Margolis & Walsh, 2003), some scholarly attention should go to establishing whether CSR practices indeed help address the societal and environmental problems they purport to address (Rupp & Mallory, 2015). Yet, in the industrial/organizational psychology tradition, the current micro-CSR research is very much focused on employees' responses that benefit the organization, rather than society or the environment (Rupp & Mallory, 2015).

Empirically, we examine the mediating effect of moral elevation on the relationship between CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder and employee OCB supporting this CSR in a vignette-based experiment and a three-wave field survey. In the survey we use a moderator – the organization's collectivistic identity orientation, which reflects a genuine care for the welfare of all stakeholders (Brickson, 2005, 2007) – to back up our claim that moral elevation is the mechanism at work. All our results support our theoretical arguments.

Our research makes two important contributions to the micro-CSR literature. First, focusing on the deontic justice path, we add a "why" to our understanding of the relationship between CSR and employees' responses. Specifically, by studying moral elevation, a mechanism closely linked to deontic justice, we provide evidence that employees' responses to CSR can indeed be attributed in part to a human tendency to care about justice for its own sake (Turillo et al., 2002). Second, we advance the understanding of the impact of CSR at the individual level by studying a type of employees' behavior that, contrary to almost all the behaviors studied in the micro-CSR literature, is not directed and intended to benefit the organization, but the stakeholder supposed to benefit from the CSR (Erdogan et al., 2015). This is an important step toward assessing under which conditions CSR motivates prosocial actions in employees that reinforce this CSR.

2. Theoretical framework

2.1. Micro-CSR research and the models of justice

The field of micro-CSR focuses on employees' perceptions of and reactions to CSR (Jones et al., 2019; Rupp et al., 2013). Micro-CSR research has provided ample evidence that CSR leads to positive behavioral, emotional, and attitudinal outcomes (Gond et al., 2017; Jones et al., 2019). For example, perceptions of CSR relate to behavior that benefits the organization, including OCB (Farooq et al., 2017) and prospective employees' choice to join the organization (Jones et al., 2014). Looking to explain these behavioral outcomes, micro-CSR researchers have shown that perceptions of CSR elicit organizational pride (De Roeck et al., 2016; Jones et al., 2014; Ng et al., 2019), which is a self-conscious emotion fostered by positive self-evaluations (Lewis, 2008). Similarly, perceptions of CSR lead employees to identify with (De Roeck et al., 2016; Farooq et al., 2017) and affectively commit to their organization (El Akremi et al., 2018; Erdogan et al., 2015). In contrast to the array of empirical evidence that employees have relational and/or instrumental reasons for working for organizations they perceive as more responsible, moral reasons remain under researched.

Theoretically however, micro-CSR scholars have drawn on the multiple needs model of organizational justice to explain why employees react to their organization's CSR (Gond et al., 2017; Rupp & Mallory, 2015). This model unifies three theoretical explanations that have appeared in the justice literature over time by proposing that individuals care about justice and how others are treated based on the fulfillment of three human basic needs (Cropanzano et al., 2001; Folger et al., 2005). Firstly, the instrumental explanation (Thibault & Walker, 1975) proposes that justice fulfills a need to control future outcomes when these outcomes are (in part) under others' control (such as the organization, for employees). Secondly, the relational explanation (Tyler & Blader, 2003) puts forward that justice fulfills a need to belong by helping individuals build a positive identity. Finally, the deontic theory of justice (Folger, 2001; Folger & Glerum, 2015) explains that justice fulfills a need to do the right thing out of a basic respect for human dignity and worth, which we evolved as a cooperative species.

In micro-CSR research, the instrumental and the relational explanations have received strong support. Employees value responsible organizations because they expect these organizations to deal with them as they deal with other stakeholders, such as treating them with respect (De Roeck & Farooq, 2018; Jones et al., 2014), care, generosity, and benevolence (El Akremi et al., 2018). CSR also signals more organizational prestige (De Roeck et al., 2016; Farooq et al., 2017), which heightens employees' pride and desire to identify with the organization (De Roeck et al., 2016; Ng et al., 2019). Thus, this body of research highlights that CSR answers employees' self-centered needs for justice.

The deontic theory of justice contrasts with these instrumental and relational explanations by emphasizing morality as a central reason driving individuals' reactions to (in)justice (Cropanzano et al., 2001; Cropanzano et al., 2003). Indeed, as CSR is at least partly directed at other actors than the employees themselves, recent micro-CSR literature has often evoked the deontic theory of justice in explaining employees' responses to CSR (e.g., De Roeck et al., 2016; Dunford et al., 2015; Rupp et al., 2006; Rupp et al., 2013).

2.2. The deontic theory of justice and CSR

According to the deontic theory of justice, justice judgments encompass principled moral obligations (Cropanzano et al., 2003; Folger & Glerum, 2015) for which social actors are accountable above and beyond any instrumental or relational consequences for the self (Cropanzano et al., 2004). The central idea is that, by virtue of their innate concern for morality, individuals hold themselves and others accountable for upholding moral principles (Folger, 2001; Folger & Glerum, 2015). This universal, evolutionary-based concern for morality (Folger et al., 2005) explains that employees' justice judgements and reactions are not only triggered by behavior that affects them personally, but extend to behavior that affects others around them in the organization and others outside the organization (Rupp, 2011). For example, empirical research has relied on the deontic theory of justice to explain employees' emotional and behavioral reactions to (un)fair treatments of their colleagues by a customer or a supervisor (Skarlicki & Kulik, 2004; Spencer & Rupp, 2009). Research has also shown that observers with no stake in the situation react to organizations' (in)justice toward their stakeholders (O'Reilly et al., 2016).

The deontic theory of justice, thus, provides a powerful framework to study how employees react emotionally and behaviorally when they observe their organization treats another party (un)fairly. This makes this theory particularly suited for micro-CSR research. CSR refers to the discretionary actions an organization undertakes to answer its stakeholders' needs (Aguinis, 2011) and thereby furthering social good (McWilliams & Siegel, 2001). Scholars in micro-CSR have argued that CSR acts for employees as a signal of the organization's morality (e.g., Rupp et al., 2013). That is, CSR reveals how the organization treats others and the degree to which it upholds or violates its normative social obligations (Aguilera et al., 2007). As such, CSR actions are often perceived by employees as morally imbued and typically lead to positive moral evaluations (Aguilera et al., 2007), which can fulfil employees' need for morality (Rupp et al., 2006).

To examine the deontic justice path, we study employees' reactions

to CSR related to a specific secondary stakeholder, namely CSR targeted at the natural environment. The literature has sometimes pictured CSR as a whole as third-party justice (e.g., De Roeck et al., 2016; Rupp, 2011; Rupp et al., 2013). However, CSR related to employees is very difficult to disentangle from first-party justice (Gond et al., 2017). Accordingly, some work in the micro-CSR stream has come to differentiate between "others-related" and "self-related" CSR in order to account for the recipient of CSR (Aguilera et al., 2007; Peloza & Shang, 2011; Rupp et al., 2013). Self-related CSR would, in our case, be CSR that is targeted at the employees themselves, while others-related CSR is CSR directed at other stakeholders.

Rather than working with others-related CSR as a whole, we chose CSR targeted at a specific secondary stakeholder for two reasons. First, others-related CSR as a whole includes CSR directed at other primary stakeholders such as customers or suppliers, who, according to stakeholder theory, are stakeholders engaged in transactions with the organization and who are essential to the organization's performance (Clarkson, 1995). CSR directed at other primary stakeholders could very well be used by employees as a proxy of first-party justice (Aguilera et al., 2007; Bridoux & Vishwanathan, 2020). It is indeed not unlikely that employees identify with other primary stakeholders because all primary stakeholders have a relatively similar relationship with the organization (i.e. they transact with the organization and as a group make an essential contribution) and employees tend to identify with similar individuals (Riketta & Van Dick, 2005). Choosing CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder (hereafter, $CSR_{2ryStkh}$), we minimize these confounding effects of first-party justice. Second, with CSR targeted at a specific stakeholder, we are able to capture employees' concern for and contributions to that specific "other" (Glavas & Godwin, 2013).

Among organizations' secondary stakeholders, we chose the natural environment. While the environment is not always classified as a stakeholder because it lacks agency (Phillips & Reichart, 2000), quite a few authors have argued in favor of considering the natural environment as a stakeholder (e.g., Driscoll & Starik, 2004). This broader conceptualization of stakeholders resonates with the empirical evidence that stakeholders see organizations as responsible for their impact on the natural environment (Öberseder et al., 2013). It is this perceived moral duty of organizations toward the environment that makes the environment a good choice of secondary stakeholder for our exploration of the deontic "path" mechanisms.

Surprisingly perhaps, to date, most authors who have formulated arguments based on deontic justice have either not included mechanisms in their empirical studies (Rupp et al., 2013) or studied mechanisms linked to the other, instrumental and relational, paths. For example, while acknowledging the importance of deontic justice, Dunford et al. (2015, p. 327) chose to focus on motives linked to the relational path on the argument that "relational attitudes (not just deontic motives) play a central role in employees' external third-party justice responses". Accordingly, they compared how first-party justice for healthcare employees and third-party justice for their patients affect relational outcomes such as organizational identification, which refers to the "perception of oneness with or belongingness to" the organization (Ashforth & Mael, 1989, p. 34) that follows from the process of incorporating the perception of oneself as a member of a particular organization into one's general self-definition (Dutton et al., 1994; Elsbach, 1999; Rousseau, 1998). In contrast, we know only three employee-focused micro-CSR articles that include a deontic path mechanism (i.e., Hericher & Bridoux, 2023; Jones et al., 2014; Raineri et al., 2022).

To understand the mechanisms underlying the deontic path, we examine moral elevation, an other-directed moral emotion elicited by observing another's good deed, as a mediator between employee perceptions of $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ and employees' behavior. Also, as employees are likely to derive the motives driving their organization's $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ from its identity orientation toward stakeholders, we use the organization's collectivistic identity orientation (Brickson, 2005, 2007), which reflects a genuine care for the welfare of stakeholders, as a moderator of the above relationship to back up our claim that moral elevation is the mechanism at play in the relationship between perceptions of $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ and employees' behavior.

2.3. Moral elevation as mechanism

In line with the deontic theory of justice, we investigate moral elevation (Romani et al., 2016; Vianello et al., 2010) as a mechanism underlying the relationship between $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ and employees' reactions. As explained above, deontic justice theory (Cropanzano et al., 2003; Folger & Cropanzano, 2001; Folger & Glerum, 2015) asserts that people have an innate moral concern for justice, and care about how others are treated, even when the treatment has no direct effect on them. Specifically, when observing a situation that involves the upholding or violation of moral obligations, people act as intuitive moralists by making quick moral judgements and experiencing moral emotions (Folger & Glerum, 2015; Haidt, 2001). According to the deontic theory of justice, moral emotions are key mediating mechanisms between an actor's behavior and subsequent observers' reactions that aim at restoring or contributing in turn to the social obligations compromised or safeguarded by the observed actions (Folger et al., 2005; Folger & Glerum, 2015). Therefore, if employees react to $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ depending on how it meets their need for morality, their primary deontic-based reactions should take the form of moral emotions (Folger & Glerum, 2015).

Moral emotions are those emotions "that are linked to the interests or welfare of society as a whole or at least of persons other than the judge or agent" (Haidt, 2003, p. 853). Moral emotions can have a negative or positive valence. When there is a violation of moral obligations, individuals experience a range of moral emotions that fall into three families: other-suffering (i.e. sympathy), other-condemning (i.e. contempt, anger, and disgust), and self-condemning (i.e. shame and guilt) emotions (For a review, see: Greenbaum et al., 2020). On the contrary, other-praising moral emotions are the "positive feelings that occur when another person upholds moral standards" (Greenbaum et al., 2020, p. 96).

According to Haidt (2003), some emotions are always moral to a high degree because they arise solely from the appraisal of the upholding or violation of moral standards, while others can be triggered by moral concerns, self-centered concerns, or a combination of both. The former type of emotions is uniquely linked to the deontic path of justice that we wish to study, while the latter type would not enable us to disentangle the moral from the relational and instrumental reasons driving employees' responses to $CSR_{2ryStkh}$. Comparing moral outrage and anger illustrates this point. Moral outrage, which is elicited by the appraisal of the violation of moral standards, is considered the prototypical example of an other-condemning moral emotion with a negative valence (Batson et al., 2007; Van de Vyver & Abrams, 2015). In contrast, anger is moral when others have been harmed, but is (partly) self-centered when the observer perceives themself as the victim (Lindebaum & Geddes, 2016).

Similarly, the moral intensity of other-praising moral emotions, which encompass gratitude and moral elevation (Greenbaum et al., 2020; Haidt, 2003), depends on who is the beneficiary of the organization's perceived good deeds. Gratitude finds its source in first-party treatment (McCullough et al., 2002; McCullough et al., 2001) and thus arises when observers witness that the organization upholds its obligations to treat them fairly (Ford et al., 2018). "[G]ratitude functions to nurture social relationships through its encouragement of reciprocal, prosocial behavior between a benefactor and recipient" (Barlett & DeSteno, 2006, p. 319). Despite the role of gratitude in nurturing prosocial behavior – e.g., grateful employees tend to reciprocate and engage in behavior that benefits the organization such as OCB (Fehr et al., 2017; Ford et al., 2018) –, the elicitors of gratitude are rather self-interested (Haidt, 2003).

In contrast to the ambiguous concerns that could drive gratitude,

moral elevation is the prototypical example of a moral emotion with a positive valence (Haidt, 2003; Van de Vyver & Abrams, 2015). Moral elevation is the other-praising moral emotion that people experience when they observe moral excellence toward another party than themselves (Aquino et al., 2011; Vianello et al., 2010). Moral elevation is, thus, elicited by a strong display of moral virtue in observers who do not benefit directly from the action (Algaoe & Haidt, 2009). This makes moral elevation an excellent candidate as mechanism for the deontic justice path.

Based on these arguments, we expect $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ to trigger moral elevation in employees, which will lead them to emulate the organization's behavior. Indeed, organizations that engage in $CSR_{2rySTkh}$, which is directed at a third party, will likely be perceived as upholding their principled moral obligations, which, according to the literature on moral emotions, should elicit moral elevation in employees who observe this type of CSR. There is already evidence that CSR can elicit moral elevation in consumers (Romani & Grappi, 2014; Romani et al., 2016; Xie et al., 2019; Zheng et al., 2019). Furthermore, we expect that moral elevation elicited by $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ will lead to employees' behavior that aims to benefit other stakeholders rather than the organization itself because moral elevation brings observers to emulate good deeds rather than to reward directly the benefactor who performed these good deeds. Experiencing moral elevation tends to translate into prosocial behavior (Algaoe & Haidt, 2009; Aquino et al., 2011). As Algaoe and Haidt (2009, p. 106) write: moral elevation "gives rise to a specific motivation or action tendency: emulation, the desire 'of doing charitable and grateful acts also'". For example, in their fourth study, Aquino et al. (2011) found that participants who were exposed to the story of a large donation to a charity experienced more moral elevation and were more likely to donate themselves to a local charity.

Among the many forms that employees' emulation could take, we have chosen to study the impact of $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ through moral elevation on OCB supporting the CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder (hereafter, OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$). OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ contrasts with traditional types of OCB that aim to benefit the organization (Organ et al., 2006). OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ aligns with the organization's CSR and aims at increasing its effectiveness (Boiral, 2009) to benefit a secondary stakeholder (Lamm et al., 2013). While most micro-CSR research has focused on traditional OCB that aims to benefit the organization (Gond et al., 2017), other researchers have proposed to extend the concept of OCB to integrate employees' discretionary behavior that aims to benefit the beneficiaries of the organization's CSR and therefore aligns with the organization's CSR (Lamm et al., 2013). Among these researchers, some have studied OCB toward the organization's CSR activities as a whole (Vlachos et al., 2014), while others have, like we do here, examined behavior targeted at a specific CSR dimension, such as the natural environment (Boiral & Paillé, 2012; Erdogan et al., 2015; Kim et al., 2017).

Based on the argument that $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ will likely elicit moral elevation and that moral elevation can translate into OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$, we hypothesize:

H1. Moral elevation will mediate the relationship between CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder ($CSR_{2rySTkh}$) and OCB supporting this CSR (OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$).

2.4. Collectivistic organizational identity orientation as evidence for our mechanism

With our second hypothesis, we aim to substantiate further that moral elevation is a mechanism at work in the relationship between the organization's $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$. To do this, we apply further the deontic theory of justice and identify a moderator that should affect the workings of our mediator, moral elevation, thereby providing additional evidence for the mechanism we propose (Spencer et al., 2005; Vancouver & Carlson, 2015).

As we have argued above, moral elevation occurs when the observer notices moral excellence toward another party (Aquino et al., 2011; Vianello et al., 2010). According to the deontic theory of justice, observers' evaluation of a behavior depends not only on its outcomes, but also on the intentions observers ascribe to the actor (Folger & Cropanzano, 2001; Folger & Shukla, 2019). In our case, it implies that employees should experience moral elevation if they see their organization's $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ as driven by moral excellence, but not if they ascribe this CSR to other motives than doing what is right. It is well known to micro-CSR scholars that employees do not only care about what the organization does, but also about its motivation for doing what it does (Donia et al., 2019; Vlachos et al., 2010).

The organizational identity orientation (OIO) signals to employees what drives the organization's CSR (Basu & Palazzo, 2008), as it captures the nature of the relationships between the organization and its stakeholders as perceived by employees (Brickson, 2005, 2007). OIO answers the question: "who are we as an organization vis-à-vis our stakeholders?" (Brickson, 2005, 2007; Brickson & Lemmon, 2009, p. 413). A strong OIO thus infuses the organization with meaning, defining appropriate goals as regards CSR (Brickson & Lemmon, 2009). Brickson (2005) identified a collectivistic OIO, on which we focus, an individualistic OIO, and a relational OIO.

A collectivistic OIO is "an organizational self-conception as a member of a larger group with generalized ties to other stakeholders in that group" (Brickson, 2007, p. 865), including secondary stakeholders that are, by definition, less able to impact the organization's business (Basu & Palazzo, 2008). Employees who perceive their organization to have a strong collectivistic OIO are likely to infer that genuine care motivates the organization's $CSR_{2rySTkh}$. Indeed, a collectivist OIO indicates that the organization sees all stakeholders as members of a community where care is the principle driving relationships (Bridoux & Stoelhorst, 2016). Thus, a strong collectivistic OIO is a signal from which employees are likely to infer a moral motivation for engaging in $CSR_{2rySTkh}$. We therefore expect a strong collectivistic OIO to enhance the link between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and our mediating mechanism, moral elevation.

In contrast, employees could perceive their organization as scoring low on a collectivistic organizational identity orientation because the organization is perceived to score high on another of the three organizational identity orientations (Brickson, 2005). In these cases, employees are less likely to see $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ as motivated by a genuine interest for secondary stakeholders' welfare and, therefore, should experience less moral elevation in reaction to the organization's $CSR_{2rySTkh}$. Indeed, an individualistic OIO refers to organizational members seeing their organization primarily as an actor distinct from its stakeholders (Brickson, 2007), which signals that the organization only pursues stakeholders' welfare when it benefits itself (Bridoux & Stoelhorst, 2016). Similarly, with a relational OIO, organizational members understand their organization first and foremost as a partner involved in dyadic relationships with specific stakeholders (Brickson & Lemmon, 2009), which signals that the welfare of these primary stakeholders is a more important goal than the welfare of other stakeholders.

To sum up, we expect the moral elevation mechanism of the deontic justice path to be enhanced by the organization's collectivistic OIO, as a stronger collectivistic OIO signals that the $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ is driven by a genuine, moral concern for the stakeholder. We thus hypothesize:

H2. Collectivistic OIO will moderate the mediated relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$, such that the relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and moral elevation will be stronger when collectivistic OIO is higher.

3. Research design and results

We conducted two studies, a vignette-based experiment and a three-wave field survey, to increase the internal and external validity of our findings. Study 1 uses an experimental design to test Hypothesis 1 in a way that enables us to establish causality between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and both moral elevation and OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ (Aguinis & Bradley, 2014). Study 2 is a longitudinal survey that enables us to test Hypothesis 1 in the field

and to test Hypothesis 2.

3.1. Study 1: Method

Participants. We recruited 150 participants on Prolific, a crowdsourcing platform created for academic research that provides high-quality data collection from people working in a wide range of organizations (Gleibs, 2017; Peer et al., 2017; Peer et al., 2022). Participants had to meet the following criteria: working for a for-profit company and living in the United Kingdom. Of the 150 recruited participants, we eliminated those who took too little time to respond, spending on average less than 1 s per item in our measurement scales (Aguinis et al., 2021), or too much time to respond, spending on average more than 15 s per item, as this indicates that these respondents were busy with other tasks while responding (Wood et al., 2017). It resulted in the exclusion of one participant, restraining the sample to 149 respondents: 64.6% identified as female, 49.0% of them reported being younger than 39 years of age, and 60.1% held a bachelor degree or higher qualifications.

Because there was no data available for an a priori power analysis, we aimed to recruit 75 participants per condition, as we calculated with G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007) that 64 participants per condition would be sufficient to detect a medium-sized effect (Effect size d = 0.50; Power = 0.80). A post hoc power analysis revealed that with our total sample of 149 individuals we attained a power of 0.99 for the smallest of our effect size d (0.70).

Procedure. To test our first hypothesis, we used an experimental vignette methodology. Experiments are regularly used in organizational research to test causal relationships (Aguinis & Bradley, 2014). Participants completed an online questionnaire that randomly assigned them to read one of our two vignettes (see Appendix A). To increase realism (Aguinis & Bradley, 2014), a paragraph preceded the vignettes to introduce a fictitious organization that engages in CSR activities. We asked participants to picture themselves as working for this company. We manipulated the level of $CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$. Following the manipulation, participants completed a survey including measures of *moral elevation* and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$. The survey also included measures of *organizational pride*, a self-directed (as opposed to other-directed) emotional reaction to CSR already studied in micro-CSR research (e.g. De Roeck et al., 2016; Jones et al., 2014; Ng et al., 2019), and *environmental self-identity*, or the extent to which individuals see themselves as pro-environmental (Ruepert et al. (2016), to rule them out as plausible alternative explanations.

Manipulation. We manipulated $CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$, using two conditions: *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ and *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$. In the two conditions, the company, named "CFN Company", engaged in an environmental program consisting of an eco-design approach, resources and energy conservation, and recycling activities. In the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition, the organization had less ambitious CSR goals than similar organizations, invested a limited amount of money in CSR, and delivered modest results. The scope of its eco-design approach, resources and energy conservation, and recycling activities was limited. In the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition, the organization had more ambitious goals than similar organizations, invested a significant amount of money in CSR, and delivered impressive results. The scope of its eco-design approach, resources and energy conservation, and recycling activities was comprehensive. We pretested our manipulation. The results are reported below under manipulation checks.

Measures. All items are found in Appendix A. We administered all our measures with a 7-point Likert scale ranging from 1 = *strongly disagree* to 7 = *strongly agree*, except for moral elevation (1 = *not at all*, 7 = *very much*). We measured *moral elevation* (α = 0.92; M = 3.43; SD = 1.64) with the 3-item scale ("touched", "inspired", and "moved") from Romani and Grappi (2014). These three items were randomly presented together with items referring to other discrete emotions, such as "ashamed", "thankful", "grateful", "remorseful", "indifferent", "joyful", "happy", and "angry". We assessed *environmental self-identity* (α = 0.94; M = 4.82; SD = 1.21) using the 3-item scale by Ruepert et al. (2016), *organizational pride* (α = 0.98; M = 5.02; SD = 1.42) with the 4-item scale by Ng et al. (2019), and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ (α = 0.95; M = 5.08; SD = 1.06) with the second-order 10-item scale of Boiral and Paillé (2012).

3.2. Study 1: Results

Manipulation check. We pretested our vignettes with an independent sample of 150 participants recruited on Prolific. These participants met the same criteria as in the experiment: working for a for-profit company and living in the United Kingdom. To verify our manipulation in the pretest, we measured $CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ with a "short-form measure using the three strongest loading items" from El Akremi et al. (2018, p. 652)'s natural environment-oriented CSR scale (α = 0.88), which the authors tested for validity. We also used an *ad hoc* 3-item scale (α = 0.97) measuring the intensity of the CSR program (see Appendix A).

We found support for the validity of our manipulation with independent sample *t*-tests using SPSS. Specifically, participants in the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition reported higher $CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ (M = 5.97; SD = 0.95) than participants in the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition (M = 4.78; SD = 0.85; $t_{(148)}$ = 8.15; p <.001; d = 1.32). Participants in the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition also reported higher intensity of the CSR program (M = 6.01; SD = 1.10) than participants in the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition (M = 3.14; SD = 1.41; $t_{(148)}$ = 13.89; p <.001; d = 2.27).

Confirmatory factor analysis. We conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) using Mplus version 8.8 with robust maximum likelihood estimation to assess the fit of our data to the measurement model and the discriminant validity of our measures. The measurement model yielded better fit to the data (χ^2[155] = 324.55, CFI = 0.94, TLI = 0.93, RMSEA = 0.09, 90% CI [0.07, 0.10]) than the alternative models reported in Table 1.

Common method variance. We used a CFA marker technique suggested by Richardson et al. (2009) to assess common method variance (CMV). We added the marker *attitude toward the color blue* measured with a 7-item scale (Miller & Simmering, 2022), and we compared the change in fit between two models: a first model in which the item loadings of the substantive constructs on the marker variable were freely estimated and a second model in which they were constrained to 0. The χ^2 difference (Satorra-Bentler scaled chi-square difference [TrD]/degrees of freedom difference [Δdf]) and other fit indices (CFI, TLI, and RMSEA) reported in Table 1 showed no significant improvement in fit when comparing the first to the second model, indicating that CMV was not a serious threat in our study.

Hypothesis testing. We tested the direct causal effect of our manipulation using independent sample *t*-tests. Fig. 1 shows that participants in the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition reported higher *moral elevation* (M = 4.24; SD = 1.47) than the ones in the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition (M = 2.56; SD = 1.33; $t_{(147)}$ = 7.32; p <.001; d = 1.20). Similarly, participants in the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition reported higher $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ (M = 5.33; SD = 1.01) than the ones in the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition (M = 4.81; SD = 1.06; $t_{(147)}$ = 3.08; p <.01; d = 0.50).

To test hypothesis 1, we ran a mediation analysis using Mplus version 8.8 with 10,000 bootstrap resamples (Preacher & Hayes, 2008). We found an indirect effect of $CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ on $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ through *moral elevation* of 0.49 (SE = 0.13), with the 95% bootstrap confidence interval (hereafter, 95% bootstrap CI) excluding zero [0.26, 0.79]. Thus, the results from Study 1 provide provisional evidence for Hypothesis 1.

To investigate the robustness of our finding, we estimated the significance of this indirect effect in the presence of a plausible, alternative mediating mechanism linked to the relational path. Micro-CSR research has provided empirical evidence that perceptions of CSR elicit *organizational pride* (e.g. De Roeck et al., 2016; Jones et al., 2014; Ng et al., 2019). Participants in the *high-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition reported higher *organizational pride* (M = 5.86; SD = 0.86) than participants in the *low-*$CSR_{2rySt\kappa h}$ condition (M = 4.11; SD = 1.34; $t_{(147)}$ = 9.51; p <.001; d = 1.56). Using both *moral elevation* and *organizational pride* as parallel mediators, results showed that the indirect effect $CSR_{2rySt\kappa}$ on *OCB-*

Table 1
Fit indices for alternative measurement models.

Model	χ2	df	Scaling correction factor	TRd/Δdf	*p*	CFI	TLI	RMSEA	LLCI	ULCI
Study 1										
1-factor[a]	1751.12	170	1.16	–	–	0.43	0.37	0.25	0.24	0.26
2-factor[b]	764.75	169	1.17	1619.05/1	< 0.001	0.79	0.76	0.15	0.14	0.17
4-factor[c]	361.79	164	1.15	275.25/5	< 0.001	0.93	0.92	0.09	0.08	0.10
6-factor[d]	324.55	155	1.13	33.00/9	< 0.001	0.94	0.93	0.09	0.07	0.10
Marker-N[e]	600.14	309	1.08	–	–	0.92	0.91	0.08	0.07	0.09
Marker-N FLC[f]	572.37	289	1.08	27.7/20	0.115	0.92	0.91	0.08	0.07	0.09
Study 2										
1-factor[a]	5792.59	434	1.18	–	–	0.34	0.29	0.19	0.18	0.19
2-factor[g]	5213.21	433	1.14	48.23/1	< 0.001	0.41	0.37	0.18	0.17	0.18
5-factor[h]	1800.26	424	1.10	1310.25/9	< 0.001	0.83	0.81	0.10	0.09	0.10
6-factor[i]	1059.86	419	1.09	425.72/5	< 0.001	0.92	0.91	0.07	0.06	0.07
8-factor[d]	920.91	406	1.08	114.57/13	< 0.001	0.94	0.93	0.06	0.05	0.06
Marker-N[e]	1267.55	637	1.07	–	–	0.94	0.93	0.05	0.05	0.06
Marker-N FLC[f]	1228.46	606	1.06	42.76/31	0.078	0.94	0.93	0.05	0.05	0.06

Notes: LLCI and ULCI: lower and upper limits of the RMSEA 90% confidence interval; TRd: Sattora-Bentler Scaled Chi-Square Difference; [a] Every item loading on one factor, [b] Emotion items loading on one factor, other items loading on another factor; [c] OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ items loading on one factor, every other item loading on its respective factor; [d] Measurement model; [e] Item loadings of the substantive constructs on the marker variable are freely estimated; [f] Item loadings of the substantive constructs on the marker variable are constrained to 0; [g] $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and collectivistic OIO items loading on one factor, other items loading on another factor; [h] OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ items loading on one factor, emotion items one factor, every other item loading on its respective factor; [i] $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ items loading on one factor, every other item loading on its respective factor.

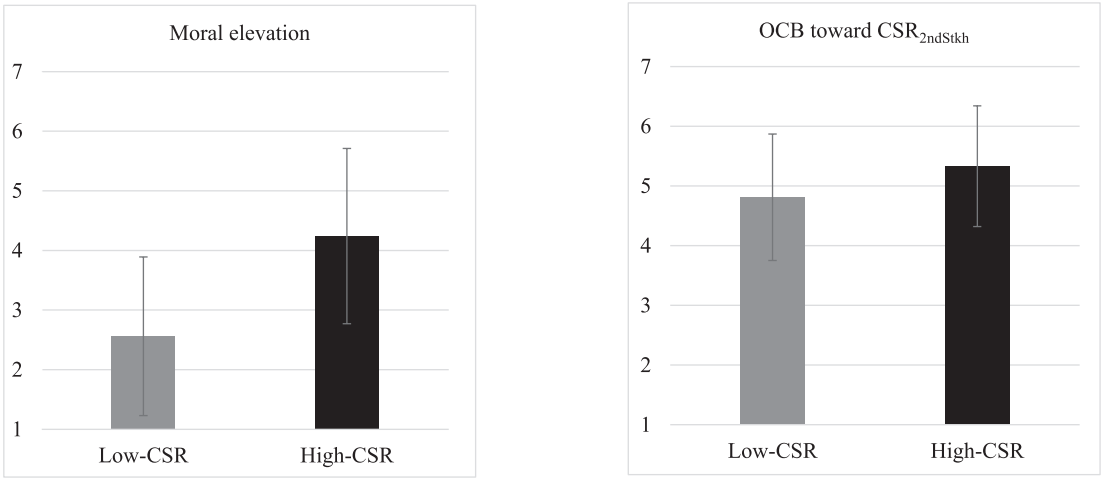


Fig. 1. Study 1: direct effect of $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ on moral elevation and on OCB toward $CSR_{2ndSTkh}$.

$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ through *moral elevation* remained significant (elevation: indirect effect = 0.33; SE = 0.12; 95% bootstrap CI [0.13, 0.61]; pride: indirect effect = 0.32; *SE* = 0.18; 95% bootstrap CI [-0.001, 0.70]). Adding environmental self-identity as control variable did not alter the significance of this hypothesized relationship either (indirect effect = 0.24; SE = 0.10; 95% bootstrap CI [0.07, 0.47]).

3.3. Study 1: Discussion

This experimental study offers causal evidence that employees exhibit both greater moral elevation and greater OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ when their organization engages more in $CSR_{2rySTkh}$. Our mediation analyses also indicate the presence of an indirect effect of $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ on OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$ via moral elevation, even when controlling for organizational pride as an alternative mediator. This finding supports the claim that there is a deontic path that is distinct from the relational path (e.g., through organizational pride; see, for instance: De Roeck et al., 2016; Ng et al., 2019) traditionally studied empirically by micro-CSR researchers.

3.4. Study 2: Method

Field survey design. Participants completed an online questionnaire at three points in time: the moderating and control variables were measured at Time 1, the independent and mediating variables at Time 2, and the dependent variable at Time 3. The lag between each measurement point was one week. To control for method bias (e.g., retrieval of information from long-term memory, implicit theories), each wave did not include focal variables measured in the other waves (Podsakoff et al., 2003).

Participants. To obtain a diverse sample of job types and organizations, we recruited 600 participants on Prolific who met the following criteria: not having participated in Study 1 or its pretest, working for a for-profit organization and living in the United Kingdom. 600 individuals answered the questionnaire at Time 1, of whom 485 (81%) completed the questionnaire at Time 2, and 437 responded to all three questionnaires (73%). Consistent with Study 1, we excluded 38 participants who took an average of less than 1 s or more than 15 s per item, leaving 399 participants. Finally, following Babu et al. (2020), we also

excluded 37 respondents who declared having no awareness of their organization's environmental CSR: they responded "nothing at all" to the item "How much do you know about your organization's environmental initiatives?" (Adapted from Du et al., 2015). Our final sample thus comprised 361 participants[1]: 57.1% identified as female, 50.4% of them reported being younger than 40, 53.9% had more than 19 years of work experience, 50.1% had less than 7 years of organizational tenure, and 64.0% held at least a bachelor's degree.

Measures. As in Study 1, we used 7-point Likert scales ranging from 1 = *strongly disagree* to 7 = *strongly agree* for all our measures, except for moral elevation (1 = *not at all*, 7 = *very much*). We measured *collectivistic OIO* ($\alpha = 0.92$) using the 4-item scale developed by Langer (2018); and $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ ($\alpha = 0.93$) with El Akremi et al.'s (2018) 7 items that environment-oriented CSR. We measured *moral elevation* ($\alpha = 0.93$) and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ ($\alpha = 0.94$) with the scales used in Study 1. Consistent with Study 1, we controlled for the potentially confounding influence of two variables: *environmental self-identity* ($\alpha = 0.96$) and *organizational pride* ($\alpha = 0.98$) (see Appendix A for all the scales).

Descriptive statistics and Cronbach's alphas are presented in Table 2.

3.5. Study 2: Results

Confirmatory factor analysis. We conducted CFAs using Mplus with robust maximum likelihood estimation. The measurement model yielded better fit to the data ($\chi^2[406] = 920.91$, CFI = 0.94, TLI = 0.93, RMSEA = 0.06, 90% CI [0.05;0.06]) than the alternative models reported in Table 1.

Common method variance. In addition to the temporal separation of measurement, a procedural remedy (Podsakoff et al., 2003), we also used the CFA marker technique described in Study 1 to assess CMV. We added the same marker variable as in Study 1, *attitude toward the color blue* ($\alpha = 0.95$), measured at Time 1, and we compared a first model in which the item loadings of the substantive constructs on the marker variable were freely estimated and a second model in which they were constrained to 0. The χ^2 difference (TrD /Δdf) and other fit indices (CFI, TLI, and RMSEA) reported in Table 1 showed no significant improvement in fit when comparing the first to the second model, indicating that CMV was not a serious threat.

Hypothesis testing. We used Latent Moderated Structural equations analysis with Mplus to test our hypotheses that involve a conditional indirect effect of *collectivistic OIO* on the first stage of the mediation between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ through *moral elevation*. We performed bootstrap analyses using estimates from 10,000 random replicates with replacement from the full sample (Preacher & Hayes, 2008).

Hypothesis 1 predicted that *moral elevation* would mediate the relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$. The results reported in Fig. 2 show a positive and significant relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and *moral elevation* ($b = 0.87$, $SE = 0.10$, $p < .001$) and between *moral elevation* and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ ($b = 0.23$, $SE = 0.05$, $p < .001$), as well as an indirect relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ through *moral elevation* (indirect effect = 0.21, $SE = 0.04$, 95% bootstrap CI [0.13, 0.31]), thus supporting Hypothesis 1.

Hypothesis 2 proposes that a collectivistic OIO moderates the mediated relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$, such that the relationship between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and *moral elevation* is stronger when *collectivistic OIO* is higher. The test of the conditional direct effect of $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and *collectivistic OIO* on moral elevation is positive and significant ($b = 0.30$, $SE = 0.05$, $p < .001$). Consistent with Hypothesis 2 we also found a significant moderated mediated effect on $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ (index of moderated mediation = 0.07, 95% bootstrap CI [0.04, 0.11]), and the indirect positive effect of $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ on $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$ was higher when *collectivistic OIO* was high (indirect effect = 0.28, 95% bootstrap CI [0.18, 0.41]) than when it was low (indirect effect = 0.13, 95% bootstrap CI [0.08, 0.21]). Fig. 3 plots the conditional indirect effect with the bootstrapping confidence interval.

3.6. Study 2: Discussion

The results of Study 2 are consistent with the findings from Study 1, and support the mediating role of moral elevation in the relation between $CSR_{2rySTkh}$ and $OCB\text{-}CSR_{2rySTkh}$. While Study 1 helped us establish causality, finding that collectivistic OIO, a firm's perceived genuine concern for secondary stakeholders' interests, moderates the mediation gives us confidence that moral elevation (i.e., the deontic path) is indeed the mechanism at work.

4. General discussion

4.1. Contributions

Our research makes two important contributions to the micro-CSR stream that relies on justice theory to explain employees' reactions to their organization's CSR (e.g., De Roeck et al., 2016; Dunford et al., 2015; Rupp et al., 2006; Rupp et al., 2013). Our first contribution is to show that moral elevation, an other-directed moral emotion, is a mechanism linking CSR and employees' responses. Thus far, CSR research grounded in justice theory has chiefly focused on studying the effect of CSR on self-centered emotions, such as organizational pride (De Roeck et al., 2016; Ng et al., 2019). In contrast, the literature had not yet studied the link between CSR and other-directed emotions, which conceptually are more closely related to the deontic justice path. Unlike organizational pride, moral elevation is an other-directed and other-praising moral emotion driven by moral excellence (Greenbaum et al., 2020). By showing that employees can experience moral elevation as a result of their organization's CSR toward a secondary stakeholder, we offer empirical support for the argument, grounded in deontic justice, that employees may care about CSR because it is the moral thing to do (in addition to caring because this CSR has personal material and/or relational benefits).

Our second contribution is to extend our understanding of the impact of CSR at the individual level by studying a type of employees' behavior that is not directed and intended to benefit the organization directly, but the stakeholder that is supposed to benefit from the CSR, here the natural environment. This enables us to take a step toward assessing whether and under which conditions CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder motivates prosocial action in employees toward the same stakeholder. Some micro-CSR researchers (Rupp & Mallory, 2015) have called to broaden the scope of micro-CSR research by studying whether CSR practices indeed help address the societal and environmental problems they purport to address. While CSR was initially promoted by researchers as a way for organizations to make a positive contribution to society and the environment (Carroll, 1991), micro-CSR research has been very focused on whether it pays off for the organization by studying only employees' responses that benefit the organization. Complementing the existing evidence for a direct positive effect for organizations in the form of employees' OCB, we have shown that CSR practices can have an indirect positive effect on a secondary stakeholder by bringing employees to act in ways that benefit that stakeholder.

Finding that the collectivistic organizational identity orientation moderates the relationship between the CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder and employee OCB toward this CSR suggests that it is only when they see this CSR as a good deed that employees experience moral elevation and are triggered to engage in OCB toward this CSR. This contributes to the literature arguing that what the organization does and what drives the organization for CSR must be congruent for CSR to have

[1] In addition to the results reported here, we tested our hypotheses on the 437- and the 399-participant samples. The results reported in Appendix B show a similar pattern of significance and comparable values for all effect estimates across the three (sub)samples.

Table 2
Study 2: Summary statistics and zero-order correlations.

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1. $CSR_{2rySTkh}$	4.64	1.26	0.92									
2. Collectivistic OIO	4.62	1.44	0.61***	0.92								
3. Moral elevation	2.74	1.67	0.65***	0.47***	0.94							
4. OCB-$CSR_{2rySTkh}$	4.28	1.24	0.35***	0.29***	0.46***	0.93						
5. Organizational pride	4.92	1.47	0.57***	0.46***	0.54***	0.25***	0.98					
6. Environmental self-identity	5.17	1.25	0.21***	0.20***	0.25***	0.56***	0.11*	0.96				
7. Gender[a]	0.43	0.50	0.06	−0.09	−0.08	−0.10	−0.08	−0.07	–			
8. Age	41.73	10.93	0.03	−0.03	0.03	0.02	0.03	0.06	0.04	–		
9. Work experience	20.38	15.52	0.02	0.00	0.00	0.02	−0.01	0.08	−0.04	0.65***	–	
10. Organizational tenure	6.49	17.65	−0.00	−0.02	−0.05	−0.01	−0.02	−0.01	0.11*	0.25***	0.15**	–
11. Education[b]	3.71	1.02	−0.03	0.06	−0.19***	0.08	−0.05	0.10	0.09	−0.17**	−0.19***	0.22

Notes: * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$; Cronbach's alphas are reported in the diagonal; [a]0 = female, 1 = male; [b]1 = no formal qualifications, 2 = GCSE, 3 = a-levels, 4 = undergraduate degree (BA/BSc/other), 5 = graduate degree (MA/MSc/MPhil/other), 6 = doctoral degree (PhD/MD/other).

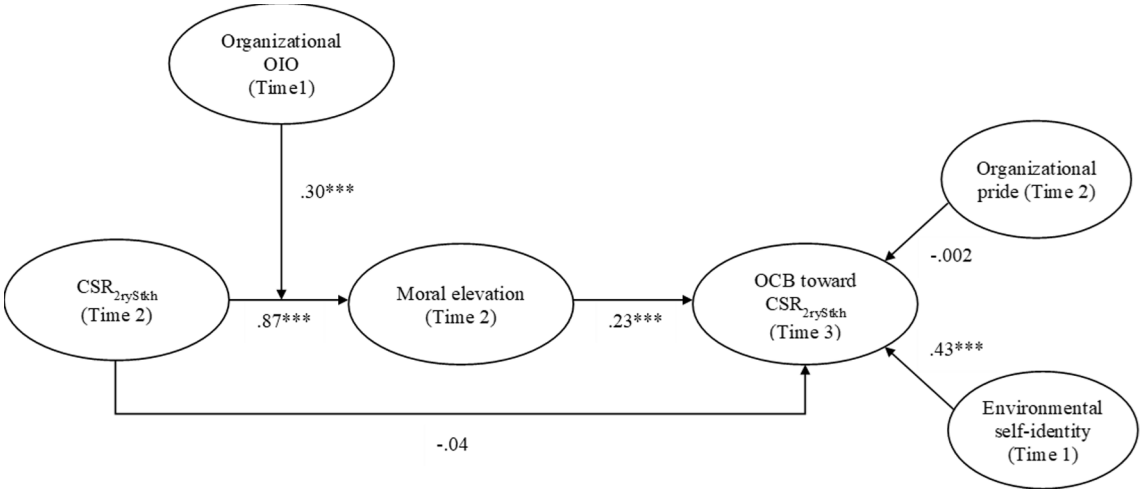


Fig. 2. Study 2: path analysis results. *Notes:* unstandardized coefficient, * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$.

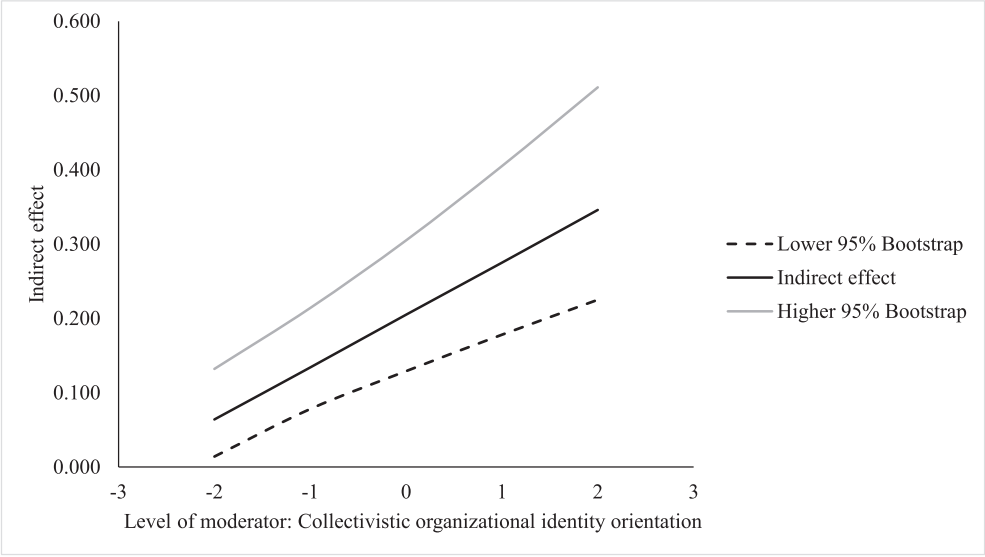


Fig. 3. Study 2: conditional indirect effect for collectivistic OIO. *Notes*: values of collectivistic OIO are standard deviations.

a positive impact on stakeholders' perceptions (Donia et al., 2019; Vlachos et al., 2014). We add to this literature by showing the important role of moral emotions in explaining stakeholders' reactions to CSR.

4.2. Practical implications

For practitioners, our research points out that CSR activities, at least the ones targeted at the natural environment, can elicit positive moral reactions in employees that can help support the organization's initial CSR efforts, particularly when employees believe their organization is genuinely committed to its stakeholders. These findings have two managerial implications. First, organizations should not only communicate about their CSR initiatives, but also about their organization's identity orientation – that is who the organization is vis-à-vis its stakeholders (Brickson, 2005, 2007) – when it is congruent with morality as a primary driver of CSR, as is the case for a collectivistic identity orientation. Specifically, we advise organizations with a collectivistic identity orientation to strengthen this identity in their employees' eyes because CSR elicits greater moral elevation when the organization is seen as genuinely caring for its stakeholders.

Second, we shed light on the virtuous cycle that CSR toward a secondary stakeholder can initiate. Employees are more likely to behave in a way that benefits secondary stakeholders when witnessing their organization's good deeds toward these stakeholders because it elicits moral elevation, a positive moral emotion that motivates employees to emulate the organization's good deeds. Employees have the potential to help improve their organization's CSR by engaging at various levels such as influencing their colleagues and leaders in addition to changing their own behavior. While research points out that CSR is often the result of a top-down process (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019), organizations gain from facilitating employees' contributions to the organization's CSR. For example, organizations can allow employees to formally engage into CSR-related behavior by setting up corporate social initiatives, which are activities with an explicitly stated social impact objective (Bode et al., 2015).

4.3. Limitations and future research

Our research has methodological strengths, but also limitations suggesting avenues for further research. First, our paper combines a vignette-based experiment to provide evidence of causality and a field study. While the design of our field study with three points in time helps reduce CMV and ensure that perceptions of CSR precede employees' reactions, this design cannot provide strong evidence of causality. We have addressed this issue to some extent using a moderator (collectivistic organizational identity orientation) that helps back up our claim of a causal relationship between the CSR targeted at the secondary stakeholder and moral elevation; we have, in contrast, less evidence to give for the causality in the relationship between moral elevation and employees' OCB supporting the CSR targeted at the secondary stakeholder. Future micro-CSR research relying on surveys should more often use moderators to test for mediation (Spencer et al., 2005; Vancouver & Carlson, 2015). Second, behavior is self-reported in both studies. Future research should obtain data from different sources, such as other-reported ratings of the outcome variable in a survey design or objective behavior in an experiment. Third, we collected all samples using Prolific, an online platform enabling researchers' data collections. This gave us access to respondents working for a large set of organizations, which means that our sample is a better reflection of the general population of employees and organizations than if we had surveyed employees in a few organizations (Newman et al., 2021). Compared to other online platforms and panels, Prolific has more diverse participants and offer higher data quality (Gleibs, 2017; Peer et al., 2017; Peer et al., 2022). However, employees of large firms are slightly overrepresented in Prolific database.

Fourth, given our focus on the deontic justice path and in line with recent research distinguishing CSR targeted at employees and CSR targeted externally (Farooq et al., 2017; Scheidler et al., 2019), we chose the natural environment as secondary stakeholder. Further research should examine whether our findings hold for, for example, CSR toward the community. It should be noted, however, that community-related CSR has a first-party justice component and a relational component for employees who feel part of that community, which may make it harder for researchers to isolate the deontic justice mechanisms from the instrumental and relational ones than is the case for CSR targeted at the environment. Employees' responses to CSR toward a community they feel part of are likely to be explained by a mix of emotions including self-centered ones such as organizational pride and other-praising ones including both gratitude (triggering the reciprocity at the basis of social exchange; cf. Barlett & DeSteno, 2006) in addition to moral elevation.

Finally, while we explored an alternative mechanism linked to the relational path, namely, organizational pride, our studies did not include controls for alternative mechanisms linked to the instrumental justice path. We made this choice because we assumed that CSR targeted at the environment brought little instrumental benefit to employees. Future research could include mechanisms linked to the instrumental path to compare the explanatory power of the instrumental, relational, and deontic mechanisms. Employees' perceived control over their future outcomes seems an interesting mechanism linked to the instrumental path (Thibault & Walker, 1975). Controlling future outcomes is a fundamental need that has been discussed under many different labels, such as a need for self-efficacy (Bandura, 1977) and a need for autonomy (Ryan & Deci, 2006). CSR targeted at employees themselves or other stakeholders that are psychologically close for employees may provide employees a sense of control over their future outcomes. The self-centered emotions corresponding most closely to the instrumental path is therefore, in our eyes, anxiety, a self-centered negative, high arousal emotion that is evoked by vague, potential threats (Harmon-Jones et al., 2016). If CSR fulfills employees' need for control over their future outcomes, it should lower employees' anxiety.

Our theoretical arguments also suggest other avenues to advance micro-CSR research. First, on the basis of the deontic theory of justice, other-directed moral emotions could be studied in relation to corporate social irresponsibility toward a secondary stakeholder. Does irresponsibility only elicit negative moral emotions directed toward the organization (anger) or does it sometimes also elicit negative moral emotions directed at oneself (guilt)? If irresponsibility elicits different negative moral emotions, do these emotions lead to different employees' behavior toward the stakeholder victim of the irresponsibility? Second, future research could extend our study by examining the effect of CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder on employees' private life behavior that benefits the target of CSR. Research on CSR-related behavior has started exploring spillovers from the non-work to the work domain (Paillé et al., 2019). Interestingly, the work sphere could be more conducive to modifying employees' private life behavior than calls by public and societal actors in the domestic sphere, as "employees are a 'captive' audience that can be more easily targeted" (Carrico & Riemer, 2011, p. 2). If CSR toward a secondary stakeholder triggers employees to behave in a way that benefits this stakeholder both on and off the job, the total impact of this CSR for that stakeholder is even larger than what we have established in our study.

To conclude, our work has provided evidence for a deontic path through moral elevation between CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder and employees' responses. This advances the micro-CSR literature, which had referred to the deontic path to explain why employees may react positively to CSR that does not deliver significant instrumental or relational benefits to them personally, but had empirically studied mechanisms that are more closely related to the relational path. In addition, we show that moral elevation is an important mechanism to explain employees' OCB that is not aim at benefiting the organization but rather at supporting the CSR targeted at the secondary stakeholder. This type of OCB had been neglected by micro-CSR researchers but must

also be studied if we want to grasp the full range of effects of CSR.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Corentin Hericher: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Flore Bridoux:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Nicolas Raineri:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Visualization, Validation, Supervision, Software, Resources, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Appendices.

Appendix A. Experimental material and scales

Study 1: experimental material

Introduction

You have been working for the past years at CFN Company. CFN Company manufactures consumer electronics such as television sets and digital cameras. Business is going well. CFN is growing in terms of revenues and employees.

Low-CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder

When you compare CFN to other manufacturing companies, you realise that its environmental programme is not very ambitious. CFN only invests around 0.5% of its annual profit in this programme. Over the past 5 years, the environmental programme has delivered some modest results. Thanks to an eco-design approach to the company's products, the percentage of recyclable materials in products increased from 0 to 20%, which is lower than what competitors have achieved over the same period. With regard to resources and energy conservation, every bathroom is now equipped with sensors that will switch off lights when not in use. Additionally, there is now a recycling program in the company for paper and plastic bottles.

High CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder

When you compare CFN to other manufacturing companies, you realise that its environmental programme is very ambitious. CFN invests up to 10% of its annual profit in this programme. Over the past 5 years, the environmental programme has delivered some impressive results. Thanks to an eco-design approach to the company's products, the percentage of recyclable materials in products increased from 0 to 80%, which is higher than what competitors have achieved over the same period. With regard to resources and energy conservation, every room is now equipped with sensors that will switch off lights and machines when not in use. Additionally, there is now a recycling program in the company for each type of waste.

Study 1: Scales

Moral elevation (Romani & Grappi, 2014)
As an employee of CFN, I would feel….
(1) Touched.
(2) Inspired.
(3) Moved.
Organizational pride (Ng et al., 2019)
(1) I would feel proud to be an employee of CFN.
(2) I would feel proud to tell others that I work for CFN.
(3) I would feel proud to identify myself personally with CFN.
(4) I would feel proud to be part of CFN.
OCB toward CSR targeted at another stakeholder (Boiral & Paillé, 2012)
Being an employee of CFN would bring me to….
Eco-civic virtue
(1) in my work, weigh the consequences of my actions before doing something that could affect the environment.
(2) voluntarily carry out environmental actions and initiatives in my daily work activities.
(3) make suggestions to my colleagues about ways to protect the environment more effectively, even when it is not my direct responsibility.
Eco-civic engagement
(4) actively participate in environmental events organised in and/or by my company.
(5) stay informed of my company's environmental initiatives.
(6) undertake environmental actions that contribute positively to the image of my organisation.

(7) volunteer for projects, endeavours or events that address environmental issues in my organisation.
Eco-helping
(8) spontaneously give my time to help my colleagues take the environment into account in everything they do at work.
(9) encourage my colleagues to adopt more environmentally conscious behaviour.
(10) encourage my colleagues to express their ideas and opinions on environmental issues.
Environmental self-identity (Ruepert et al., 2016)
(1) Acting pro-environmentally is an important part of who I am.
(2) I am the type of person who acts pro-environmentally.
(3) I see myself as a pro-environmental person.
Items for manipulation check: CSR (El Akremi et al., 2018)
(1) CFN takes action to reduce pollution related to its activities (e.g. choice of materials, eco-design, and dematerialisation).
(2) CFN contributes toward saving resources and energy (e.g. recycling, waste management).
(3) CFN makes investments to improve the ecological quality of its products and services.
Items for manipulation check: CSR intensity (*ad hoc*)
(1) CFN has an ambitious environmental programme.
(2) CFN puts a great deal of efforts in its environmental programme.
(3) CFN invests a lot in its environmental programme.

Study 2: Scales

Perceptions of CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder (El Akremi et al., 2018)
(1) My company takes action to reduce pollution related to its activities (e.g. choice of materials, eco-design, and dematerialisation).
(2) My company contributes toward saving resources and energy (e.g. recycling, waste management).
(3) My company makes investments to improve the ecological quality of its products and services.
(4) My company respects and promotes the protection of biodiversity (i.e. the variety and diversity of species).
(5) My company measures the impact of its activities on the natural environment (e.g. carbon audit, reduction of greenhouse gas emissions, global warming).
(6) My company invests in clean technologies and renewable energies.
(7) My company encourages its members to adopt eco-friendly behavior (sort trash, save water and electricity) to protect the natural environment.
Collectivistic organizational identity orientation (Langer, 2018)
(1) My organization can be described as cause-driven.
(2) My organization emphasizes the importance of its affiliation with a group, cause or broader community.
(3) My organization considers itself to be "doing well" when it contributes to well-being of a broader group, cause or community.
(4) My organization is extremely motivated to advance the welfare of a broader community or cause.
Moral elevation (Romani & Grappi, 2014)
Taking into consideration my company environmental initiatives, I feel….
(1) Touched.
(2) Inspired.
(3) Moved.
OCB toward CSR targeted at a secondary stakeholder (Boiral & Paillé, 2012)
Eco-civic virtue
(1) In my work, I weigh the consequences of my actions before doing something that could affect the environment.
(2) I voluntarily carry out environmental actions and initiatives in my daily work activities.
(3) I make suggestions to my colleagues about ways to protect the environment more effectively, even when it is not my direct responsibility.
Eco-civic engagement
(4) I actively participate in environmental events organised in and/or by my company.
(5) I stay informed of my company's environmental initiatives.
(6) I undertake environmental actions that contribute positively to the image of my organization.
(7) I volunteer for projects, endeavours or events that address environmental issues in my organization.
Eco-helping
(8) I spontaneously give my time to help my colleagues take the environment into account in everything they do at work.
(9) I encourage my colleagues to adopt more environmentally conscious behaviour.
(10) I encourage my colleagues to express their ideas and opinions on environmental issues.
Organizational pride (Ng. et al., 2019)
(1) I feel proud to be an employee of this organization.
(2) I feel proud to tell others that I work for this organization.
(3) I feel proud to identify myself personally with this organization.
(4) I am proud to be part of this organization.
Environmental self-identity (Ruepert et al., 2016)
(1) Acting pro-environmentally is an important part of who I am.
(2) I am the type of person who acts pro-environmentally.
(3) I see myself as a pro-environmental person.

Appendix B. Path analysis results for full sample and subsamples

Path	Effect	S.E.	p-value	95% bootstrap CI ULCI	95% bootstrap CI LLCI
437-participant sample[a]					
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → Moral elevation	0.80	0.08	< 0.001		
Moral elevation → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	0.26	0.05	< 0.001		
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	−0.03	0.07	0.692		
Indirect effect of $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ on OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ via Moral elevation	0.21	0.04		0.14	0.30
Conditional mediating effect, lower collectivistic OIO	0.13	0.03		0.08	0.20
Conditional mediating effect, higher collectivistic OIO	0.28	0.05		0.19	0.40
Index of moderated mediation	0.08	0.02		0.05	0.11
399-participant sample[b]					
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → Moral elevation	0.83	0.08	< 0.001		
Moral elevation → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	0.24	0.04	< 0.001		
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	−0.03	0.07	0.688		
Indirect effect of $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ on OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ via Moral elevation	0.20	0.04		0.13	0.29
Conditional mediating effect, lower collectivistic OIO	0.10	0.07		0.07	0.20
Conditional mediating effect, higher collectivistic OIO	0.25	0.06		0.18	0.39
Index of moderated mediation	0.07	0.02		0.05	0.11
361-participant sample[c]					
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → Moral elevation	0.87	0.10	< 0.001		
Moral elevation → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	0.23	0.05	< 0.001		
$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ → OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$	−0.04	0.07	0.563		
Indirect effect of $CSR_{2ryStkh}$ on OCB-$CSR_{2ryStkh}$ via Moral elevation	0.21	0.04		0.13	0.31
Conditional mediating effect, lower collectivistic OIO	0.13	0.03		0.08	0.21
Conditional mediating effect, higher collectivistic OIO	0.28	0.06		0.18	0.41
Index of moderated mediation	0.07	0.02		0.04	0.11

[a]full 437-participant sample; [b]437-participant sample minus 39 participants identified as 'careless'; [c]399-participant sample minus 38 participants who declared not knowing anything about their company's environmental initiatives.

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